

RECORD OF INTERROGATION: CROOKGATE KEEP

[The chamber is narrow, windowless, and cold. A hooded recorder sits behind a desk of blackened wood. Across from the recorder sits the prisoner, wrists bound before him. No seal is displayed.]

RECORDER: State what you know of Crookgate Keep.

PRISONER: It stands in the Weeping Marshes.

RECORDER: That is not sufficient.

PRISONER: Crookgate Keep was founded in 294 AS. It lies outside the realm's core holdings. It is contested.

[The recorder's quill pauses. The prisoner watches the nib rather than the hooded face.]

RECORDER: Contested by whom?

PRISONER: *By those who say it is theirs.*

RECORDER: Names.

PRISONER: I heard none that can be safely repeated.

RECORDER: You are not being asked what is safe. You are being asked what is true.

PRISONER: Truth is the property of The Silent Choir, is it not?

[A second figure, previously unseen, closes the door.]

RECORDER: Explain.

PRISONER: The Silent Choir is a secretive priesthood. It records history, censors history, and rewrites history. Its religious authority is exercised through control of the historical record. If the Choir writes that Crookgate Keep was founded in another year, then that is the year that survives.

RECORDER: And what year survives?

PRISONER: 294 AS.

RECORDER: You hesitate.

PRISONER: I hesitate because the Choir is quiet, inscrutable, and deliberate in its handling of truth. Their priests keep records as other folk keep knives. Their appearance is priestly and restrained, all secrecy and careful custody. I cannot tell whether the entry was preserved or merely permitted.

RECORDER: Did House Morvain possess Crookgate Keep?

PRISONER: I did not say that.

RECORDER: Did House Morvain claim it?

PRISONER: I did not say that either.

RECORDER: Then speak of House Morvain.

PRISONER: House Morvain is an ancient noble house claiming descent from the last Sunder-Kings. Its authority rests upon the dynastic claim and the weight of its antiquity. It bears itself in an aristocratic, kingly fashion, guarded and proud. Its entitlement is ancestral. Whether the ancestry is true is a question for the Choir, and questions are the Choir's preferred prison.

RECORDER: Is Crookgate Keep theirs?

PRISONER: Crookgate Keep is contested.

[The recorder scrapes a line through the answer.]

RECORDER: You repeat yourself.

PRISONER: That is because the answer remains.

RECORDER: Who taught you to speak so carefully?

PRISONER: The marsh did.

[Silence. The quill resumes. The final line is written in a hand unlike the first.]

RECORDER'S ENDORSEMENT: The witness confirms nothing beyond the

founding of Crookgate Keep in 294 AS, its position in the Weeping Marshes, its contested status, and its location outside the realm's core holdings. Further testimony is withheld pending correction.